

According to Prof. V.N. Rajasekharan Pillai, the present Vice Chancellor of the University, in today's times, the Open and Distance Learning (ODL) has a decisive role to play in the creation of a global knowledge-based society.

Prof. Pillai also seeks to dispel the misconceptions about this particular model of learning, especially in the employment market. It is assumed that in this format there is no face-to-face interaction and students get a degree just by registering themselves at the varsity. With satellite and online classes, it is becoming possible to teach an individual rather than a class.

Please shed some light on the role of Distance Education in India and its spread under the aegis of IGNOU.

Learning is for all-round development. The conventional teaching-learning methods cannot cope with the scale of modern educational challenges, particularly in highly populated developing countries like India, where not every child or youngster has access to a school or college.

At the same time, we should also be careful that education should not just focus only on bookish knowledge improvement. It should help improve the health of people and increase their incomes, especially in rural areas. We should link learning with better livelihood opportunities. Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU), Distance Education Council, 14 State Open Universities, over 150 distance education institutes in the Conventional Universities and Several other private open and distance and e-learning centres are involved in the country in providing such alternative and flexible modes of education in the country.

What is the scope and role of Distance Education and Institution like IGNOU which is also policy and guideline maker of Distance Education Council?

We live in an age where Open and Distance Learning (ODL) is recognised and accepted as an indispensable part of the mainstream education system. ODL is playing a decisive role in the creation of a global knowledge-based society and is fast developing as a force contributing to social and economic development. The conventional teaching methods are being supplemented by systems enabled with Information and Communication Technologies (ICT). Hence, this system has significant pedagogical, organisational and economic implications. In the knowledge-intensive, internationalised education scenario, an institution like IGNOU has immense potential.

But isn't distance education always rated as supplementary education and not as the methodology that can complement the existing education systems ?

It is true that despite the growth in the ODL system, misconceptions abound in the society and particularly in the employment market. It is assumed that in this format there is no face-to-face interaction and students get a degree just by registering themselves at the varsity. To quell these notions we have to promote vigorous interaction between the teacher and the learner. With satellite and online classes, it is becoming possible to teach an individual rather than a class. But if this link is weak, then open learning is just like a correspondence course. At IGNOU, we have been able to maintain the distinction.

How is it helping students from rural areas that lack basic infrastructure of education?

Hampered by many factors such as lack of infrastructure, access, teachers etc., the quality of education in rural areas has been quite poor. High dropout rates and low enrolment have contributed to the large illiterate population in Indian villages.

The open education system can help as it can reach students in interior regions and help them receive formal education without migrating to cities. It also makes sense to explore the potential of open and distance learning systems to reach communities in far-flung areas or those rendered less accessible by law and order problems.

Does IGNOU cater to the modern day requirements of education and career building ?

The importance of the major determinants of development has changed over the past few decades. A shift is taking place from manufacturing to services and from capital resources to knowledge resources. Today, knowledge is considered a key to escape both poverty and marginalisation. In 2007, we launched 10 new schools in the country. They are School of Gender and Development Studies, School of Journalism and New Media Studies, School of Translation Studies and Training, School of Social Work, School of Foreign Languages, School of Tourism and Hospitality Service Sectoral Management, School of Vocational education and Training, School of Performing and Visual Arts, School of Extension and Development Studies and School of Interdisciplinary and Transdisciplinary Studies. A large number of new activities were also initiated from the existing established 11 Schools of the University.

How is IGNOU trying to meet the requirements of the Corporate India which needs quality skilled manpower rather than just graduates? Is it also encouraging private participation for the spread of Distance Education?

Governmental bodies have come to recognise that public and state investments alone are inadequate to meet the growing demand for education at both basic and tertiary levels. The private sector, which needs a steady flow of human talent to lead its operations, has also accepted this reality. It is in the private sector's interest to help the government develop the country's human resources. Needless to say, a public-private partnership to achieve national education goals works to the benefit of all. IGNOU is in the process of establishing effective public-private partnerships in creating technology-enabled education facilities across the country, particularly in rural areas, for providing education, training and capacity building at all levels.

Quality of Education is also dependent upon the quality of teachers specially in the field of higher education. What are the efforts done by IGNOU for the same?

The university has established a Chair to promote research and education in the field of sustainable science. The urgency of shifting to a sustainable pattern of economic development has become obvious in the context of global warming and climate change, triggered by anthropogenic pressures. The Chair will create various courses and training programmes for all levels of education including scientists and decision makers.

Please share with us your plans for the forthcoming academic year?

It has been a fulfilling year for everyone at IGNOU in terms of surpassing achievements over the previous year. Our student enrolment is 1.85 million now. We have exceeded the national target of enrolling 33 percent of women and 22.5 percent of SC/ST students. The number of programmes run by the University has gone up to 129 from 74; the number of regional centres has increased to 59 from 46 and of study centres to 1,438 from 1,081.

IGNOU is also set to launch several new courses and formal study programmes on social work and HIV/AIDS, masters in social work (MSW) from July 2008. Besides, a PG diploma in social work may also be launched from January 2009. Our channel Gyan Darshan, now reaches one million homes through Direct-to-Home TV.